



Agenda

- Stress and work related stress: some statistics
- Impact on industry: more work related stress claims?
- Why is stress not good for your health
- Some people feel more stressed than others – why is that?
- What causes work related stress?
- Signs and symptoms
- Recognising valid WRS claims – Friends Life
- Interventions
- Reflections
- Do zebras get ulcers? - answer
- Useful resources

General Public Release

Changing trends? The media

The Telegraph

Home News World Sport **Business** Comment Culture Travel Life Women Fashion
Language | Community | Personal Finance | Economics | Markets | Journal of Business | Year in Review

BUZZ > BUSINESS > NEWS

Stress overtakes cancer as main cause of sickness absence
Stress has become the main cause of long-term sickness absence for the first time across the British workforce, overtaking acute illnesses like cancer, a survey showed today.



For office-based workers, stress has overtaken acute illnesses like cancer as being the main reason employees take sickness absence, the GfK survey revealed. *By: Harry*



- The total number of working days lost due to stress, depression or anxiety was 11.3 million in 2013/14, an average of 23 days per case of stress, depression or anxiety (HSE, 2014)

Swiss Re

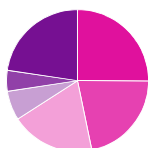
3

General Public Release

Sickness Absence – Industry trends

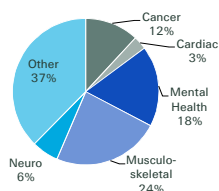
Claims Watch 2012 cause of new claims

Individual



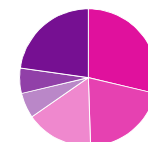
25%	Musculoskeletal
22%	Mental health
19%	Cancer
7%	Neurological
5%	Cardiac
23%	Other

Claims Watch 2014 cause of new claims (decisions)



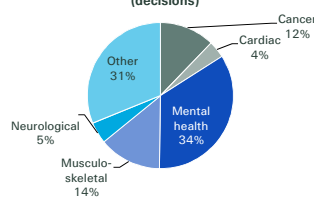
Claims Watch 2012, cause of new GIP claims

Group



29%	Mental health
21%	Cancer
16%	Musculoskeletal
6%	Neurological
6%	Cardiac
23%	Other

Claims Watch 2014, cause of new claims (decisions)



Swiss Re

What does research tell us?

Severe medical conditions and permanent impairment (neurological disease, amputations, and blindness) account for less than one quarter of long term sickness in the normal population of the UK (Waddell and Aylward 2010).

But what is Work Related Stress (WRS)?

- Stress is our cognitive, emotional and physical response to pressure
- It occurs when "when there is a mismatch between ***perceived threat*** and ***perceived ability*** to cope" (Lazarus & Folkman)
- When the demands of work exceed the individual's ability to cope
(Health & Safety Executive, HSE)
- Results in psychological and physical symptoms that can cause sickness absence, poor productivity and human error
- Associated with poorly designed jobs, workflow issues, poor management and their interaction with different individuals

General Public Release

Why some people feel more stressed than others?



- Type A personality
- Coping styles
- Life Stressors
- Job strain
- Locus of control
- Social support
- Caring for others

General Public Release

Why is stress not good for your health

Direct

- Undermines immune system (catching more colds?)
- release of glucocorticoids : impacts cognitive function: ability to learn, problem solve, memory
- Risk of cardiovascular disease
- Obesity

Indirect

- Life style route
- Coping styles (unhealthy behaviours)
- Risk of cardiovascular disease
- Obesity

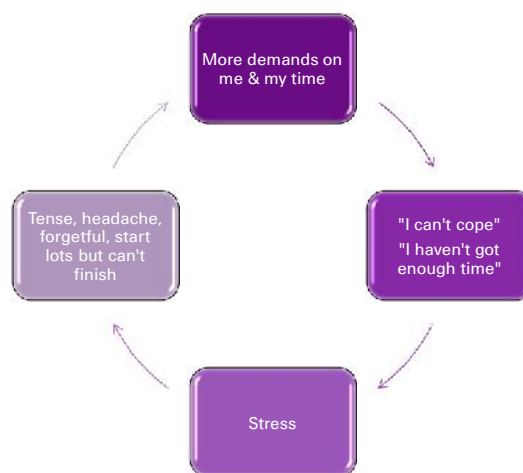
General Public Release

Work place implications

- Job demand control model (Karasek, 1979)
- high demand – low control
- Overtime work +11hrs a day (Virtanen et al 2012)
- middle management: high responsibility minimal control
- Grievances
- Job dissatisfaction

General Public Release

Vicious cycle of stress – signs and symptoms



General Public Release

Implications for DI claims

- WRS is not a medical condition
- Stress symptoms can be similar to anxiety/depression
- Chronic stress can lead to the development of a mental health condition such as anxiety, depression or both.
- Chronic stress refers to stress that has been present for at least 6 months.
- Consider deferred periods
- Consider policy definition (own –suited-any?)



General Public Release

Recognising Valid Work Related Stress claims

Jackie Kerwood

Katie Block

**FriendsLife**
12

Indicators of a valid work related stress claim

General Public Release

Symptoms

- Severity
- Longevity
- Impact
- Resistance to treatment

Treatment

- Treatment regime
- Effectiveness
- Compliance
- Referrals

Presentation and history

- Initial and ongoing presentations
- Previous history
- Underlying medical problem

Indicators of a valid work related stress claim (continued)

General Public Release

Medical Evidence

- Consistency

Other

- Employer support
- Occupational health records
- External factors



General Public Release

Interventions – What reduces stress?

- General advice
- Connecting with others
- Physical activity
- laughter
- Giving - charity
- Workplace interventions
- Increase control (how to) and predictability
- Fairness
- reward
- Wellness programmes (Mindfulness meditation)
- Mediation

General Public Release

Challenges in the claims environment

Employer

Expectations
Headcount

Workplace
Demands



Employee

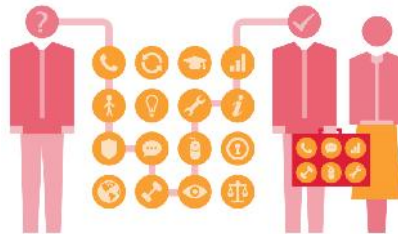
Fears
Self-
Confidence

Embarrass
ment

Stigma

General Public Release

Claims interventions for WRS cases



- Proactive holistic claims management approach
- Telephone skills – understanding the individual BPS factors
- Use of work focused interventions

General Public Release

Reflections

- ✓ Stress is the number 1 cause of sickness absence in the UK – how does this impact the DI claims environment?
- ✓ Individual, work and social factors are all important determinants of whether someone will develop work stress or not
- ✓ Prolonged exposure to a stressful work environment can cause a sickness absence episode to anyone
- ✓ WRS claims are difficult to assess and manage: there isn't a script to follow
- ✓ Understanding the person from a biospsychosocial perspective can help identify the most appropriate course of action
- ✓ Telephone skills are a useful way to gather all risk factors to plan a proactive claims management plan
- ✓ Work focused interventions can help address work issues and facilitate a sustainable return to work

General Public Release

Do zebras get ulcers?

- Apparently not



General Public Release

Useful resources

- Stress, portrait of a killer – documentary. R Sapolsky (2008)
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eYG0ZuTv5rs>
- Why Zebras don't get ulcers – book. R Sapolsky.
- Mind <http://www.mind.org.uk/>
- Health Safety Executive
<http://www.hse.gov.uk/>

Questions

Monica Garcia, BSc , MSc Health Psych. | Claims Medical Expert | Vice President | Life & Health Business Management
Swiss Re Europe S.A., UK branch | 30 St. Mary Axe, EC3A 8EP London, United Kingdom
Direct: +44 20 7933 3509 Fax: +44 20 7933 5509 E-mail:
Monica_Garcia@swissre.com

Legal notice

©2015 Swiss Re. All rights reserved. You are not permitted to create any modifications or derivative works of this presentation or to use it for commercial or other public purposes without the prior written permission of Swiss Re.

The information and opinions contained in the presentation are provided as at the date of the presentation and are subject to change without notice. Although the information used was taken from reliable sources, Swiss Re does not accept any responsibility for the accuracy or comprehensiveness of the details given. All liability for the accuracy and completeness thereof or for any damage or loss resulting from the use of the information contained in this presentation is expressly excluded. Under no circumstances shall Swiss Re or its Group companies be liable for any financial or consequential loss relating to this presentation.